MEKONG-GANGA COOPERATION (MGC)

The MGC was formally launched on 10th November 2000 in the Laotian capital of Vientiane. MGC focuses on building cooperation in sectors of tourism, culture, educational contacts and transport and communications between India and these five Greater Mekong Sub-region (GMS) countries which are Cambodia, Lao PDR, Myanmar, Thailand and Vietnam. These five GMS countries had begun, much before the formation of MGC, a cooperation initiative named 'Mekong-Ganga Swarnabhoomi Programme'. MGC only institutionalized their cooperation by providing a much stronger platform.

First MGC Ministerial Meeting was held at Vientiane (Lao, PDR) on 10th November 2000. This led the foundation of the MGC. The outcome of the Meet was the adoption of the *Vientiane Declaration*. This Declaration underscored the identification of the member countries' common heritage and desire to enhance friendship. The Declaration outlined MGC objectives in four specific sectors of—Tourism, Culture, Education and Transport and Communications. It also committed the member states to strengthen their cooperation in the development of Information Technology (IT) infrastructure. The Second MGC Ministerial Meeting was held in Hanoi, 28 July, 2001. The Meet concluded with the adoption of the Hanoi Programme of Action affirming their commitment to cooperate in four areas of cooperation. The Hanoi Programme of Action targeted 6 years timeframe from 2001 to 2007 with the progress of its implementation being reviewed after every two years. The Third MGC Ministerial Meeting was held in Phnom Penh on 20 June 2003. The Phnom Penh Road Map was adopted as a plan to accelerate the implementation of all MGC projects and activities. In the absence of Fourth Ministerial Meeting taking place in 2004 or 2005, the Annual MGC Senior Officials Meeting was held in New Delhi on 25th May 2005. The long-awaited Fourth MGCI Ministerial Meeting was held in New Delhi on 12 October 2006. The then Indian foreign minister, Pranab Mukherjee reiterated India's commitment to strengthen India's cultural and commercial ties with GMS countries. The Fifth MGC Ministerial Meeting, Cebu, 12 January 2007. In this meeting,